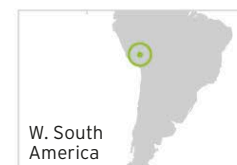


The Quelccaya Ice Cap

The largest glaciated area in the world's tropical regions, located in the Cordillera Oriental of the Peruvian Andes



The Quelccaya Ice Cap covers an area of 17 square miles (44 square km) of the High Andes and—reflecting how high the freezing zone is in the tropics—all of it lies above an altitude of 16,000 ft (5,000 m). The ice cap is of great importance to the surrounding region because its meltwater irrigates fields in the valleys below and provides drinking water for some large Peruvian cities, like Cusco. However, due to global warming, the ice cap has lost about one-fifth of its area over the past 30 years, and the rate at which it is shrinking is accelerating. The recent appearance of 5,700-year-old plant remains from under the ice cap indicate that more than 50 centuries have passed since it was smaller than it is today.

▷ KEYHOLE LAGOON

This unusual-looking keyhole-shaped feature is a meltwater lake—temporarily iced over—that developed on one edge of the ice cap in the 2000s.

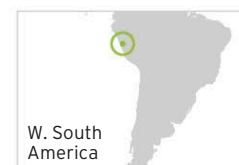


The **ice cap** lies close to the **Amazon rain forest**, where **temperatures** are about **80°F (27°C)** higher



The Pastoruri Glacier

A small Peruvian glacier that is shrinking but still a remarkable sight and a magnet for enthusiasts of various snow- and ice-related sports



The Pastoruri Glacier lies in the southern part of the Cordillera Blanca in the Andes of north central Peru, occupying one flank of a 17,200-ft- (5,240-m-) high Andean peak called Nevado Pastoruri. It is a cirque glacier—a type of glacier that occupies a bowl-shaped depression high up on a mountain.

Steep sides

The Pastoruri Glacier has steep, clifflike edges, making it a popular destination for ice climbers. Although parts of its surface are heavily crevassed, others are often covered in deep, soft snow, which attracts skiers and snowboarders. The glacier has lost over 15 percent of its ice over the past 35 years, and it is expected to continue to shrink.

▷ BLUE ICE CAVE

Inside the Pastoruri Glacier, at a height of around 17,000 ft (5,200 m), there is an ice cave. Visitors can hike around the glacier and visit the glowing blue interior.

